



How to Make the Most of a Facilitated Conversation

UNC-Chapel Hill Ombuds Office

What is a facilitated conversation?

A conversation among two or more individuals who have agreed to discuss a complex or challenging topic with the help of an ombuds facilitator providing a structured and supportive environment.

What is the role of the ombuds facilitator?

The facilitator will remain impartial concerning the topics discussed while cultivating and holding a space for the conversation. In practical terms, this means the facilitator will help participants develop an outline of *what* will be discussed and agreements on *how* they want to engage during the conversation. The facilitator will remind participants of the agreements as needed and will work to keep the conversation constructive.

What Can I Do to Prepare?

1. *Consider the Big Picture.* Reflect on your work at UNC and why it is important to you. What values guide your work and the way you hope to interact with others?
2. *Consider the Purpose of the Conversation.* What are your hopes for the facilitated conversation? Think about why this is important to you and write down a clear goal or goals for the conversation.
3. *Consider Your Role in the Conversation.* Think about what you can do to help achieve the goals you identified for the conversation. How would you describe your contribution? What is your responsibility to other participants in the conversation?
4. *Consider What We Need for an Open and Honest Conversation.* We will work together to establish some guidelines on how we want to communicate. Think ahead about what you need to feel heard, e.g. agreeing not to interrupt each other.
5. *Listening and Curiosity.* Resolve to listen carefully to what all participants in the conversation have to say. Approach the conversation with a spirit of curiosity and a desire to fully understand the experiences and viewpoints of others. Try to suspend your assumptions about others' intentions.
6. *Patience.* Come prepared to stick with it through the challenging moments. Expect that there will be points of disagreement that will remain unresolved.
7. *Honesty and Mindfulness.* Plan to be honest about your experiences and perspective while remaining mindful of other participants. Be prepared to ask questions to check for understanding, celebrate even small wins and agreements, and express disagreement without shutting down the conversation.
8. *Give Yourself Credit.* It takes courage and commitment to engage in this type of discussion.